

keepsake, and his consequent denial of reality through flights of imagination. But the boy's final vision leads to no feelings of humility and remorse, as a true Bunyanesque allegory of vanity at the fair should. On the contrary, in the inflated rhetoric of the transformation scene at the end, we find the boy playing the Manganian hero one more time, alternately inventing, effacing, and enlarging himself, now in the Araby of his own memory. At this mythopoetic level, "Araby" seems another fictional biography of Mangan, the Irish Orientalist, or perhaps an early fictional autobiography of Joyce in the process of reinventing himself.

Abbreviations

- CW Joyce, James. *The Critical Writings of James Joyce*, ed. Ellsworth Mason and Richard Ellmann. New York: Viking Press, 1959.
- D Joyce, James. *Dubliners*, ed. Robert Scholes in consultation with Richard Ellmann. New York: Viking Press, 1967.
- FW Joyce, James. *Finnegans Wake*. New York: Viking Press, 1939; London: Faber and Faber, 1939. These two editions have identical pagination.
- JJII Ellmann, Richard. *James Joyce*. New York: Oxford UP, 1959.
- Letters Joyce, James. *Letters of James Joyce*. Vols. II and III, ed. Richard Ellmann. New York: Viking Press, 1966.
- U Joyce, James. *Ulysses*, ed. Hans Walter Gabler et al. New York and London: Garland, 1984, 1986.

MARGOT NORRIS

The Perils of "Eveline"†

With a small aside tucked into his brilliant 1972 essay called "Molly's Masterstroke," Hugh Kenner turned the *Dubliners* story "Eveline" upside down by listening to a couple of commas. Kenner quotes the narration—" 'He had fallen on his feet in Buenos Ayres [comma] he said [comma] and had come over to the old country just for a holiday' " (20). Kenner goes on to say, "Great issues may be said to hang on those commas, which stipulate not only that Eveline is quoting Frank, but that Frank has been quoting also: quoting from the kind of fiction Eveline will believe, the fiction in which ready lads 'fall on their feet' " (20). The upshot of listening carefully for the literary in these repeated and reported conversational snatches is that Kenner

† From *Suspicious Readings of Joyce's Dubliners* (Philadelphia: U of Pennsylvania P, 2003), pp. 55–67. Reprinted by permission of the University of Pennsylvania Press. Parenthetical page references are to James Joyce, *Dubliners: Text and Criticism*, ed. Robert Scholes and A. Walton Litz (New York: Penguin Books, 1996).

is able to speculate a different end to Eveline's adventure than the one she had fantasized. It is a different ending, too, from what the reader is likely to imagine: "The hidden story of 'Eveline' is the story of Frank, a bounder with a glib line, who tried to pick himself up a piece of skirt. She will spend her life regretting the great refusal. But what she refused was just what her father would have said it was, the patter of an experienced seducer" (21). Kenner's reading turned the story away from its more conventional and superficial reading as an exemplar of Dublin paralysis, and brought it into the more sophisticated tradition of Continental "logocentric" writing. In this species of intertextual fiction (of which Flaubert's *Madame Bovary* is an excellent example) both the sentimental and melodramatic novel are refigured by showing impressionable young women seduced and abandoned first by the romance novels they take as models for their own choices. R. B. Kershner agrees with Hugh Kenner, when he writes that "As Kenner recognizes, she really has no choice but to fictionalize her choices" (62). In a more recent essay published in *Semicolonial Joyce*, Katherine Mullin further argues that in addition to romance novels, Eveline would also have been vulnerable to a different sort of textual influence: the competing and conflicting emigration propaganda current in Ireland at the turn of the century.¹

The elegance of Kenner's reading has survived even the convincing challenges posed to it by Sidney Feshbach, and although Feshbach makes a strong case that Frank's conviction as a bounder can be disputed with historical and other evidence, he cannot rule it out altogether. I hope to take up this challenge in a different vein, by asking the question that Kenner doesn't ask until later, in *Joyce's Voices*. Why does the story of Eveline's close shave with disgrace and ruin remain "a hidden story," as Kenner calls it, and why doesn't the third person narrator simply tell us what is going on? My own readings of the *Dubliners* stories repeatedly produce many such "hidden stories" concealed by the narrative voice, including another hidden seduction and swindle in the story that immediately follows "Eveline": "After the Race." This narrative complicity with seduction and betrayal intrigues me. What is at stake in keeping the reader in the dark about what is going on, and obliging the reader to draw inferences, to speculate, to take risks in creating scenarios from uncertain and partial information? Hugh Kenner seems to suggest that Joyce delights in seducing and betraying the reader in order to expose reader fatuousness—"Penny romances are the liturgy of the inno-

1. Katherine Mullin historically identifies three types of emigration propaganda a young, single, literate female in turn-of-the-century Ireland might have had to adjudicate. The first promised successful pioneering in Argentina, the second exposed the plight of misled Irish immigrants, and the third conjured the prostitution in the white slave trade as the lurid fate of the single, unprotected female émigré. "Eveline is the propagandist's sitting target," Mullin writes (197).

cent. The reader believes such stuff" (81). But I will suggest that the narrative stance may have a different and more benign purpose in "Eveline." The reader obliged to make dubious inferences, to be suspicious, to speculate with fragmented and incomplete information, to create scenarios that are unverified and unverifiable occupies a position very similar to Eveline's own. By withholding knowledge about Frank and his motives in courting Eveline, the narration obliges the reader to participate emotionally in Eveline's dilemma in making an agonizing and difficult life decision whose outcome risks disaster for her whatever and however she chooses. The story may therefore have a large and serious objective when it forces readers into Eveline's own interpretive crisis. Its aim may be to recreate in the reading experience the epistemological anguish faced by immense numbers of Irish persons in the course of that country's history when confronting the decision of whether or not to emigrate. Written before Ireland's great economic recovery in the late 1990s, Brenda Maddox writes on the first page of her 1988 biography *Nora*:—"In every young Irish mind, the question of emigration is as inescapable as it has been since the Great Famine of the 1840s" (3). Katherine Mullin has further explored how prospective emigrants from Ireland were historically belabored with varieties of propaganda both to stimulate and allure migrants to New Worlds, or to serve nationalist efforts to stem the tide of emigration with frightening warnings and exposés.

The story itself makes only a few references to emigration, but they are sufficient to indicate that Eveline has at least a subliminal awareness of the social mobility and population movement that is going on around her—"Everything changes" (37), she thinks. The childhood friends with whom she played in the field built over by the Belfast developer have dispersed—"Tizzie Dunn was dead, too and the Waters had gone back to England" (37). Her father, she learns, also saw schoolmates emigrate to such faraway places as Australia. "He is in Melbourne now" (37), Mr. Hill tells of the priest in the yellowed photograph on the wall. Indeed, Eveline's father has an insular sense of Irish emigration and southern European immigration—" 'Damned Italians! coming over here!' " (40) he complains—while Don Gifford maintains that "There is no evidence of a significant Italian immigration to Ireland during this period" (51). Rather, Gifford suggests, the Italians in Ireland at that time might have been failed immigrants—like Frank McCourt's luckless family in *Angela's Ashes*—on their way back to the old country after unsuccessful efforts to get established in America. "Frank" himself—whatever his real name—would have been one of thousands who left the Ireland of his day to seek a better life elsewhere. Brenda Maddox reports that in 1904, 37,413 Irishmen and women left Ireland for

better lives elsewhere, including, of course, James Joyce and Nora Barnacle (46). Whatever the temptation to join Eveline's father and Hugh Kenner in stereotyping sailors as "experienced seducer[s]" (Kenner 21), "Frank" deserves to be counted as an émigré in the larger social context of the story. Indeed, Sidney Feshbach historically supports Frank's story by citing the huge immigration that made turn-of-the-century Buenos Aires a city whose adult population was three-quarters European-born, including not only Italians and French immigrants, but also Irish, Welsh, and Scotch (224). However, Katherine Mullin's statistical table of Irish emigration to Argentina shows zero movement for 1902 and 1903—and she argues that at the time the story was written, the "stereotype" of the successful Irish pioneer in Argentina "had become obsolete" (176). Nonetheless, Eveline, in contemplating her escape, explicitly counts herself as part of an Irish diaspora—"Now she was going to go away like the others, to leave her home" (37).

Inserted into this context of Irish emigration in the story is the focus on the erosion of Eveline's decision by indecision. The brooding of this young store clerk and involuntary homemaker and surrogate mother takes form as an attempt to sift and evaluate her alternatives through a series of memories,² fantasies, images, echoes, and fictions. Together these constitute a welter of what Jean-François Lyotard would call "phrases in dispute"—conflicting and competing discourses that are difficult to adjudicate because they convey different criteria and because their genres and objects are incommensurate. The discourses rioting through Eveline's mind are highly heterogeneous, a cacophony of voices in a jumble of emotional registers—fear, anxiety, desire, longing. Some are unpleasant and threatening: little Keogh warning of the approach of her father and his blackthorn stick, Miss Gavan's reproving "Miss Hill, don't you see these ladies are waiting. . . . Look lively, Miss Hill, please" (37), and her father's sarcasm ("had she any intention of buying Sunday's dinner" [38]) and threats ("what he would do to her only for her dead mother's sake" [38]). Comfort, stimulation, and hope come to Eveline through fiction and art, as both Kenner and Kershner have argued. She fondly remembers the ghost story her father tells her when she is ill,³ and enjoys the Freudian family romance of abduction and restoration to noble estate in Balfe's opera *The Bohemian Girl*. And she listens to the "tales of distant countries" and "stories of the terrible Patagonians" (39) with which Frank, like a

2. Benoît Tadié has a particularly interesting analysis of the locutions of Eveline's memory in the story (379).

3. Brenda Maddox reports that Nora Joyce's father, Tom Barnacle, was a drunkard, like Mr. Hill, who could also be very nice with the children at times. Like Eveline, Nora and her sisters "remember how he told them ghost stories before the fire" (14).

modern Othello, seduces her.⁴ And finally, of course, there is the siren song Frank sings to her, and tacitly prompts her to emulate, about "the lass that loves a sailor" (39).

Eveline's indecision arises from her inability to adjudicate between the unpleasant realities of a "Home!" (39) that she knows, and an abroad ("Escape!") that is unknowable and that presents itself to her as patently fabulous. But dichotomizing the safe if dreary knowability of Eveline's "home" with the dangerous but exciting unknowability of "abroad" reductively polarizes and simplifies choices that are far more inscrutable and complex. Nineteen-year-old Eveline counts at least two deaths among her contemporaries—those of her favorite brother Ernest and her playmate Tizzie Dunn. The Ireland of home, the narrative implies, may not necessarily be safer than emigration abroad—the moral of Frank McCourt's memoir of a disastrous Irish repatriation.⁵ The ultimate moment of terror that convinces Eveline that she must leave is her recognition that if physical escape from the horrors of home is impossible, if—like Eveline's mother—one can't run away or emigrate, then the foreign and the fabulous will "invade" and colonize the domestic, the home, the mind, until one speaks a terrible, untranslatable language ("Derevaun Seraun! Derevaun Seraun!" [40]) to the tune of an Italian organ grinder. Eveline's mother had transmogrified before her daughter's stricken eyes into an alien, a foreign creature, a domestic Patagonian, and Eveline's choice is therefore much more complex and desperate than choosing between level-headed reality and a flight into fantasy. The betrayal Eveline risks in running away with Frank is not necessarily more egregious than the broken promises Eveline's mother suffered. These promises, literally sacred, had been codified under the aegis of the Sacred Heart of Jesus and Blessed Margaret Mary Alacoque, and displayed on the parlor wall. "I will establish peace in their homes," they promised Mrs. Hill, "I will comfort them in all their afflictions," "I will be their secure refuge during life, and above all in death" (Gifford 49). Eveline's mother clearly found neither peace, nor comfort, nor security in her Irish home—either in life or in dying. And Garry Leonard intriguingly suggests that in her discordant linguistic

4. Darwin's voyage to Tierra del Fuego on the *Beagle* had stimulated general European interest in Patagonians. Sidney Feshbach writes, "In 1830, three aborigines 'were abducted' from Patagonia or Tierra del Fuego 'and brought to England' for exhibition and education" (224). Katherine Mullin, however, points out that "Frank's tales of the terrible Patagonians are tall because the Patagonians became extinct many years before his birth" (176).

5. The Pulitzer Prize-winning 1996 chronicle tells of the McCourt family returning to the slums of Limerick after failing to make a go of it in Brooklyn in the Depression, and enduring extreme poverty, near-starvation, typhoid, and the death of several of the children. The memoir begins with the sentence, "My father and mother should have stayed in New York where they had met and married, and where I was born. Instead, they returned to Ireland" (11).

registers, Eveline's mother gives her daughter contradictory and impossible mandates: to hold the home together *and* to save herself from a "life of commonplace sacrifices closing in final craziness" (40).

The difficulty with Kenner's melodramatic scenario of a seduced and abandoned Eveline, is that it offers a glib and easy answer to her dilemma. His reading reduces the story to a single tragic irony: that Eveline would spend the rest of her life regretting a choice that was unwittingly the right one. But was it the correct choice? While Katherine Mullin concurs with Kenner when she characterizes Frank's enticements as "misleading and exploitative emigration propaganda" (177), she also exposes the seduction and betrayal narratives of "social purity campaigners" as a "white slave trade scare" (183).⁶ Garry Leonard convincingly challenges the easy assumption that remaining home was the safe choice when he refers to Eveline's twilight meditation as "this frightening lull in her life, a lull that almost certainly precedes the occasion of being beaten for the first time by her father" (96). Both Garry Leonard and Suzette Henke see the menacing and abusive father as a potentially greater threat to Eveline's safety and welfare⁷ than the risk of possible seduction and abandonment by a lying sailor. But the point of the story may be less the adjudication of the correct choice than to have the reader experience the interpretive difficulty and desperate uncertainty of making such a life-altering choice. The Kenner theory sets aside as irrelevant the most interesting movement in the story, which is the difficulty of adjudicating alternatives with incommensurate risks—what Suzette Henke, in a psychoanalytic and religious gloss, calls a "trial of the soul" (22). "Eveline serves both as prosecutor, and defendant, analyst and spiritual analyst and" in weighing "emotion and romantic fantasy against the judgmental voice of conscience," Henke writes. Robert Scholes's theoretically groundbreaking "Semiotic Approaches to a Fictional Text: Joyce's 'Eveline'," adumbrates the internal complexity of Eveline's "brooding" most precisely—especially with respect to her necessary negotiations of past and future. Scholes places stress on what he calls "focus"—"aspects of the events in any story maybe clarified by the narrative focus, while others may be hidden or obscured, temporarily or permanently" (74). The story's "focus" prods him into scrutinizing not only the narrative rhetoric,

6. Mullin notes that Joyce bought and owned a copy of Olive Mac Kirdy's *The White Slave Market*, which was published in 1912. But while Joyce wrote "Eveline" many years prior to acquiring this book, Mullen points out that "By 1904 the city [Buenos Ayres] was perceived to be the international capital of the White Slave Trade" (189).

7. Luke Gibbons fills in the broader historical and social conditions that are thought to have contributed to the dysfunctionality in post-Famine colonial Ireland (168). These include, in addition to the absence of an urban manufacturing base, the absence of a social reform agenda on the part of the Catholic Church and lack of legal protection afforded to women against domestic violence.

as Kenner does, but also the temporal rhythms (duration and frequency) of Eveline's deliberative process. "She had consented to go away, to leave her home. Was that wise? She tried to weigh each side of the question" (37), the narrator tells us. Like any momentous decision, Eveline's decision to emigrate appears incapable of escaping provisionality and iterability even after it has ostensibly been "made." She seems to have conveyed her decision to Frank for implementation before she has made her peace with it, and in the hours before departure she again rehearses the pros and cons while passage is being booked and arrangements are being made. "The white of two letters in her lap grew indistinct. One was to Harry; the other was to her father" (39). The letters defer the announcement of her decision to her family in a maneuver that simultaneously prevents obstruction of her escape and allows her to defer burning her bridges until the last possible moment. The *time* at issue in her realization that "Her time was running out" (39) is not only her time in her Dublin home, but also her time for continued deliberation.⁸ Eveline's panic attack at the dock may reflect less her cowardice or passivity than her distress that her endless, judicious weighing of pros and cons has come to an end before it has produced a reliable resolution to her dilemma.

Is Eveline as fatuous as Kenner supposes her to be? Is she what Robert Scholes calls "a central intelligence who is not very intelligent" (75)? Or is Eveline Hill far more realistic and circumspect in her considerations than, say, a Gerty MacDowell, dreaming of Reggy Wylie and a dark stranger with burning eyes on Sandymount Strand? Curiously, what follows after the narrative tells us that "She consented to go away, to leave her home" (37) is not a rush of romantic thoughts of Frank, the anticipated sea voyage, the upcoming marriage, and fantasies of a home in exotic South America. Instead, her first thought is an absolutely prosaic acknowledgment that in her present circumstance she is assured the fundamentals for survival ("In her home anyway she had shelter and food" [37])—an admission that implies her awareness that these necessities cannot be taken for granted once she leaves home. We quickly learn what that Dublin shelter and food costs her. Not only does she work at the Stores under an edgy and deprecating supervisor all day. She then returns to the house of her menacing and deprecating father ("she sometimes felt herself in danger of her father's violence" [38]) who makes her beg for her own wages back so she can feed his younger children and clean his dusty house. Nor does she imagine that news of her elopement will incite jealousy in her female coworkers, speculating

8. Benoît Tadié describes Eveline's dilemma as better appreciated in terms of verbal tense, than of time, and calls it a "verbal deadlock which can account for the aphasic collapse of the central character at the end of the story" (379).

rather that they will "Say she was a fool perhaps" (37). If anything is remarkable in these early passages, it is how resolutely Eveline refuses to cast herself as a romantic heroine. Eveline's description of her anticipated life with Frank may lack naturalistic specificity—"She was to go away with him by the night-boat to be his wife and to live with him in Buenos Ayres where he had a home waiting for her" (38). But neither does it indulge in the sort of aesthetic domestic fantasy we find in Gerty MacDowell's dreams of "a beautifully appointed drawingroom with pictures and engravings . . . and chintz covers for the chairs and that silver toastrack in Clery's summer jumble sales" (13.231). Perhaps it is Hugh Kenner who may be embroidering the simple description we get of Eveline's plan. He describes Frank's improbable success—"a Dublin sailor-boy has grown affluent in South America, and bought a house and sailed all the way back to Ireland to find him a bride to fill it" ("Molly's Masterstroke" 20). *Joyce's Voices* repeats this characterization, of Frank as "a sailor who has 'fallen on his feet in Buenos Ayres,'" who "has bought a house there and is spending a holiday in a rented room in Ireland." Frank's proposal is again described as a willingness to "take her back as his bride to that South American house, though for some reason not gone into they can't get married till they've gotten there" (81). But the text says nothing of Frank's buying a house in Buenos Aires—only that "he had a home waiting for her" (38).⁹ And Sidney Feshbach may be on to something when he writes, "As for the question about why Eveline doesn't think about the house she is going to, the answer may be that she is avoiding thinking about still another house to dust" (224). In other words, Eveline's allusion to the home Frank has waiting for her may be no more than a reassurance to herself that in Buenos Aires she will still have "shelter and food" (37), as she does in her father's house. Perhaps knowing what she does about houses and their care, Eveline simply cannot imagine domestic settings as sites of marital bliss. As for Kenner's question about why Frank won't marry Eveline until they get to Buenos Aires, there are several possibilities. The most cogent is that the Catholic Church's requirement of published banns announcing upcoming marriages would have made a secret marriage impossible in Dublin. And Eveline's father, having forbidden her to see Frank, could be expected to interfere with any publicized plan for the marriage of his

9. The discrepancy between the "house" of Kenner's account, and the "home" of the 1967 and 1996 Penguin editions—edited by Scholes and Litz—that I have been using, may be an editorial one. In his original "Molly's Masterstroke" article in the Fall 1972 *James Joyce Quarterly*, Hugh Kenner explicitly "quotes" *house* as the word used in the text of "Eveline." Kenner writes, "And he had come to Dublin, it seems, to obtain a bride, and take her back to Buenos Aires, where (to quote again) 'he had a house waiting for her.'" (20). But the article has no footnote, and it is unclear which edition Kenner might have been using. Kenner's 1978 *Joyce's Voices*, which again mentions Frank's "house," has no bibliography so that the edition of *Dubliners* to which he refers is once again indeterminate.

nineteen year-old daughter. Brenda Maddox reminds us that, when Nora Barnacle eloped with Joyce at the age of twenty, "she was still a minor" (4).

Frank lends himself to easy typology as the predatory and faithless sailor because of the extent to which he appears deracinated both within and by the narrative: given no clear origin, no "people" identified by class, geography, or business. The business that seems to have finally grounded him in Buenos Aires, allowing him to leave off sailing and to settle in one place, does indeed lack the specificity of Harry Hill's work in "the church decorating business" (38). But Hugh Kenner's famous commas ("He had fallen on his feet in Buenos Ayres, he said, and had come over to the old country just for a holiday" [39]) offer a different interpretation as well. Eveline may realize full well that she has only Frank's word for his South American condition, and she may therefore recognize how perilous it is to trust a visiting stranger in the face of her father's ominous warning, "I know those sailor chaps" (39). Perhaps it is precisely to disrupt that stereotype that Frank gives Eveline an extremely specific employment history—"He had started as a deck boy at a pound a month on a ship of the Allen Line going out to Canada. He told her the names of the ships he had been on and the names of the different services" (39)—one that a suspicious father would be capable of checking out if he was concerned about his daughter's welfare. Sidney Feshbach does what Eveline's father does not: he checks up on Frank's story. He determines that the Allen line did indeed conduct travelers between England and North America, and that (according to James Skobie's *Revolution on the Pampas*) Irish manual laborers in South America earned excellent wages. A rural migrant worker living in Argentina in the 1890s could apparently pay for a round trip passage between the U.S. and Europe with two weeks worth of wages (224), and therefore afford to return home on holiday. "On point after point, Frank's story checks out," Feshbach writes (225). Tales and yarns constitute the time-honored social and cultural capital of sailors, as Joseph Conrad demonstrates in his fictions. But telling stories of "the terrible Patagonians" to Eveline does not, in and of itself, turn Frank into a D. B. Murphy.

Part of the difficulty in forming a just assessment of Frank's character may be attributed to the uncertain sequence through which the narrative gives us certain information about him. One particularly illogical sequence has the information that Eveline's "father had found out the affair and had forbidden her to have anything to say to him," followed by the information that "One day he had quarrelled with Frank and after that she had to meet her lover secretly" (39). The first statement suggests that Hill learns that his daughter is seeing a sailor, and forbids her to see him again, without ever having

laid eyes on the young man. The second statement suggests that father and suitor have met on more than one occasion, and that the father's ban of his daughter's trysts was the result of a specific disagreement with Frank. If so, what did they quarrel about? Did Hill try to pry into Frank's financial condition and meet a rebuff? Did he insult Frank by calling him a bounder? Did the quarrel ensue on a Saturday night when Frank watched Eveline try to wrest some of her wages back from her father in order to shop for Sunday's dinner? Did Frank remonstrate with Hill about his drunkenness, or defend Eveline against her father's abuse in some other way? Was the quarrel about something inconsequential that merely symptomized Hill's jealousy of his daughter's sexual maturation and independence? Eveline, after all, appeared to have had no expectations of ever leaving the parental home—"Perhaps she would never see again those familiar objects from which she had never dreamed of being divided" (37). Besides the ellipsis marking Eveline's standing up in terror in her room and her paralysis on the dock, there are other ellipses in this story whose content informs her decision-making process without our ability to adjudicate it.

If Eveline is remarkably restrained in imagining the *material* details of her future life with Frank in South America, she is also relatively restrained in the rhetoric imputed to her imaginings of her *emotional* life with him. For a girl ostensibly bedazzled by a handsome sailor, her feelings for him are repeatedly expressed in language that points to her concerns for safety and security, rather than to infatuation. Before we receive any description of Frank, he is mediated as the invisible vehicle for bestowing respectful treatment on her, giving her the kind of Hegelian recognition that would constitute her as a person, a subject in her own eyes: "Then she would be married—she, Eveline. People would treat her with respect then. She would not be treated as her mother had been" (37). Garry Leonard points out the fallacy of this line of reasoning, that it was precisely marriage that visited poor treatment on Eveline's mother (102). And he astutely suggests that Eveline's desire throughout the story is consistently pointed toward an indefinable "elsewhere" that may be equated with unrepresentable female desire, or *jouissance*. Clearly, the notion of *difference* between her present known life and her future unknown life, is what Eveline's ruminations attempt to dilate—expressed by the narrative in the open-ended trope of exploration, "She was about to *explore* another life with Frank" (38, my emphasis). The narrative description given of Frank is indeed flattering. Eveline thinks him "very kind, manly, open-hearted," handsome ("his hair tumbled forward over a face of bronze"), and solicitous ("He used to meet her outside the stores every evening and see her home"). The evidence of his actions does nothing to under-

mine this judgment. He generously takes her to good seats at the opera, sings for her, gives her playful nicknames ("Poppens," "Evie"), and, of course, tells her about both himself and his tales of distant countries (38–39). Eveline's responses to this highly conventional but flawless courtship is surprisingly measured and cautious, "First of all it had been an excitement for her to have a fellow and then she had begun to like him" (39). Rather than fatuity, the most consistent note that runs throughout Eveline's meditation appears one of thoughtful calculation and consideration. She proceeds as though the explicit warnings of her father, and the tacit proleptic denunciations of her coworkers who would think her a fool for running away with a sailor, were not without effect on her deliberations. After all, Eveline knows from her father that occasional charm and kindness can coexist with relentless oppression and exploitation in the same masculine personality. And although she has no grounds for expecting ill from Frank, neither does she have guarantees that his courtship generosity and affection will endure. When her final image of her demented mother seems to snap her decision into place—"Escape! She must escape! Frank would save her. He would give her life, perhaps love, too. But she wanted to live. Why should she be unhappy? She had a right to happiness. Frank would take her in his arms, fold her in his arms. He would save her" (40)—the tropes all point to safety, security, and freedom from abuse and abasement, rather than toward romantic or sexual fulfillment. "He would give her life, perhaps love, too" is a curiously qualified locution for the thoughts of a bedazzled girl—and, indeed, nowhere does the story tell us that Eveline is in love with Frank, or loves Frank, or that he has told her he loves her. Eveline's fantasy of Frank enfolding her in his arms has an emotional cast that differs markedly from Gerty MacDowell's dream of a "manly man," who would "take her in his sheltering arms, strain her to him in all the strength of his deep passionate nature and comfort her with a long long kiss. It would be like heaven" (13.210).

The hidden story of "Eveline" has many possibilities, including one that corresponds to the overt narrative. Frank could have been a seducer transformed into a savior:¹ moved by the plight of a girl he began by playfully seducing, he determines to take her away from a stultifying and dangerous home, for example. The nature of the promises that have passed between the couple are left sketchy and undetailed. Eveline has "consented" to go away with Frank to Buenos Aires; he has promised to marry her and give her a home there. The registers of emotional intimacy and commitment that may or may not inform such pledges are highly variable and incalculable in any

1. Torchiana writes of Frank, "I shall even be bold enough to liken him to the Christ who revealed Himself to Margaret Mary" (73).

union, and they remind us that marriage is itself an act of emotional emigration, a commitment to traverse to a different emotional, domestic, and social sphere. The vow that seems to count most in Eveline's deliberations is that Frank has promised to take care of her. Having made and fulfilled such a promise herself—to her dying mother—Eveline can both understand it and believe in the possibility that it can be honored. She can even understand its costs and rewards: "It was hard work—a hard life—but now that she was about to leave it she did not find it a wholly undesirable life" (38). Hugh Kenner concedes Eveline's concession, that in some ways her Dublin home life "is not a bad life." "But," he goes on, "it does not compare in glamour with the life Frank seems to be offering her" (20). Yet there is so little evocation of exotic glamour in Eveline's musings that some critics have imagined a gender role reversal in which it is Eveline who is the betrayer, and Frank who is betrayed. Sondra Melzer asks, "Is the innocent Eveline capable of using Frank as a passport from her present life, even with the implication that their mutual love (or at least hers) was uncertain?" (482). This suggestion opens the possibility of speculating an utterly prosaic basis to the elopement of the lass and her sailor: that of a bargained arrangement between the pair. Its fulcrum, for both the man and the woman, may have been a measure of emotional containment within security rather than romance, passion, or adventure—"He would give her life, perhaps love, too" (40). Such arrangements entail risks for both partners, and although the reader's sense of Eveline's physical and emotional perils is much greater, she clearly feels that Frank has also made a material and emotional investment in their elopement. Her most painful regret on the dock is not the loss of the love of her life but a crippling sense of her own ingratitude: "Could she still draw back after all he had done for her? Her distress awoke a nausea in her body and she kept moving her lips in silent fervent prayer" (41).

The "hidden story" that Hugh Kenner imputes to "Eveline" is produced by holes and ellipses in the story. Robert Scholes names these "paralipse," a discursive strategy identified by Gérard Genette. Scholes writes, "He points to the tendency of fictions to employ strategies he calls 'paralipse' or 'paralepse': that is, the withholding from the reader of information which he 'ought—according to the prevailing focus—to receive; and the presenting to the reader of information which the prevailing level of focalization 'ought' to render inaccessible. Joyce, it seems to me, is a highly paraleptic writer, in 'Eveline' and in other works as well" (75). The most significant ellipsis in the story is, of course, what happens in Eveline's mind between her two extreme and opposite terrors: her memory of her mother's dementia spurring her to escape and her paralysis on the dock when she cannot go. The interval is blank: we learn neither how she gets

from her home to the North Wall, nor what, if any thoughts, have shaken her shaky resolve to go through with their plan.² The scene Eveline encounters at the dock reminds us of the first sentence of Brenda Maddox's 1988 biography of *Nora*: "To this day departures by sea from Ireland are noisy, anxious affairs" (3). Maddox is merely describing the modern overnight ferry crossing from Ireland to Euston Station in London. But her evocation of chaos, fatigue, and worry can be multiplied to imagine Eveline's confusion and distress on the dock, full of soldiers and brown baggage, with the whistles and bells of the steamer announcing its imminent departure. After the stillness and solitude of her twilight reverie, the sense of congested motion and human engulfment Eveline experiences on her way toward the ship conjures up in powerful figurative tropes the phenomenology of emigration. Joyce's description particularly evokes the disorientation and estrangement of joining a large aggregation of strangers in a simultaneous yet noncollective movement away from their homelands. And in another ellipsis, neither Eveline nor the reader hears what Frank is telling her "over and over again" about the passage. Is it something to do with where the ship is going, to Buenos Aires or Liverpool, as Hugh Kenner surmises (*The Pound Era* 37)? Or is he telling her that instead of steaming toward Buenos Aires in one of the staterooms with their "illuminated portholes," they will be in steerage with the other immigrants? Not yet on board, is Eveline already experiencing the sensations of the seaborne immigrant—not dancing merrily like the lively crowd below deck in the film *Titanic*—but uncomfortable, ill, and frightened? Eveline's last-minute sensation of nausea and fear of drowning—"All the seas of the world tumbled about her heart. He was drawing her into them: he would drown her" (41)—scarcely seems an unrealistic prolepsis of the immigration voyage.

This negative scenario of a failure to emigrate, of fear of emigration, throws into positive relief the courage required to do so, by the thousands of Irish poor who over the years made their escapes to difficult but different lives abroad.³ By recovering the biographical

2. David Weir points out that the story elides all of the actions Eveline takes to prepare for her journey—"packing her baggage, writing a farewell note to her father, catching a tram, walking briskly to the North Wall" (345). The effect of this elision, he argues, is to have the narrative replace "passage" with representations of the "passive" (345).
3. J. C. Beckett argues that the Great Famine of 1846 altered the emigration practices of the Irish. "Emigration, formerly a last desperate remedy, was now the first thing thought of; and there was an almost hysterical rush to leave the country, to escape, at all costs, from 'the doomed and starving island,' and find safety elsewhere," he writes. He goes on to say that "In earlier years, emigrant sailings had been confined to spring and summer; and intending emigrants had made their preparations carefully. But, from the latter half of 1846 onwards, the panic-stricken crowds were clamorous to be off without delay; the traffic continued throughout the year; and thousands of helpless refugees put to sea with only the scantiest supply of provisions for the voyage, and without either means of subsistence or prospect of employment on their arrival" (344).

moment in which this story was written, one can speculatively give Eveline's moment of panic and fear of peril an informative context and illuminating range. As we all know, James Joyce met Nora Barnacle on June 10, 1904 and eloped with the unmarried twenty-year-old on the night of October 8, 1904—not quite four months later. During this interval Joyce wrote the first two *Dubliners* stories for the *Irish Homestead*—"The Sisters" and "Eveline," which was published on September 10, 1904 (Werner 35). The coincidence between Nora's situation during this interval and the *donnée* of "Eveline" is, as has often been noted, no coincidence at all. Joyce imported dozens of narrative similarities between his own and Nora's domestic situations into the story, to give its dispiriting home scenes their plausible textures. Eveline's fear of her father's blackthorn stick reflects the violence of Nora's uncle Tom Healy, who beat her with a stick for going out with Willie Mulvagh, according to Brenda Maddox (22). Like Eveline, Nora was then forced to date her young man secretly. Like Eveline, Joyce experienced the death of a beloved brother, George, and, of course, the death of an overworked, exhausted, and abused mother. After the death of their mother, Joyce's sisters were left with the care of the younger children with virtually no provision from a drunken father—a plight dramatized both in Stanislaus Joyce's diary and in "Wandering Rocks" in *Ulysses*. Although Joyce was not a sailor like Frank, Richard Ellmann reported that he looked like one to Nora—"She took him, with his yachting cap, for a sailor" (*JJII* 156). And Hugh Kenner points to the Constantine P. Curran photo of Joyce to note that "Frank" is Joyce's first "Portrait of the Artist" (*The Pound Era* 35). Joyce himself was more improvident than any sailor, making Nora's elopement at least as great a risk as Eveline's. "Nora appreciated the enormity of her decision, even though Joyce feared she did not," Brenda Maddox wrote. "By running away unmarried, she too was breaking with the social order and committing an open act of rebellion. She was burning her bridges and she had no way of supporting herself abroad if Joyce left her. In a non-English speaking country she was unlikely to find work even as a domestic servant" (45). Furthermore, Joyce's friends expected the worst from him—"George Russell said he pitied the poor girl, whom Joyce would certainly abandon" (45).

"Eveline" was written as Joyce was preparing to elope with a twenty-year-old woman who barely knew him, and to whom he had little to offer, except—like Frank—a love of music and a promise to enfold her in his arms. It is intriguing to remember that when the story was published in the *Irish Homestead* on September 10, 1904, Joyce did not yet know the outcome of his and Nora's own plan. What, then, did it mean for Joyce to write a predictive ending to his own elopement scenario in which the beloved refuses to go through

with it? Sondra Melzer speculates that the story enacts Joyce's ambivalences about taking Nora Barnacle into his artist's exile with him. She writes, "It must have occurred to Joyce that his own simple country girl, Nora, might see him as a means of escape from the conventionality of her life, just as Eveline saw in Frank an opportunity to escape. On the other hand, did Joyce fear that Nora, upon whom he had come to depend, in some way had cheated or would cheat him of the freedom and independence he sought as artist and rebel?" (482). Melzer's point reminds us of a dramatic gender difference in portraying male and female emigration decisions in Joyce's fiction. Stephen Dedalus's diary entries at the end of *Portrait* mythologize the emigration decision as heroic—"I go to encounter for the millionth time the reality of experience and to forge in the smithy of my soul the uncreated conscience of my race" (276). This rhetoric stands in marked contrast to Eveline's "She had consented to go away, to leave her home. Was that wise?" (37). My own alternative to Sondra Melzer's biographical reading of Eveline's decision is to see the story as a dramatized projection of the perilous emotional and rational process entailed by a decision like Nora's to emigrate by way of an elopement. By making Eveline's South American destination much more foreign and remote than Nora's expatriation to the Continent, the risks she faces are intensified, and the perils of her decision are vastly multiplied. Katherine Mullin's account of the pressures of Irish anti-emigration propaganda in 1904, and particularly the scary warnings to single women to beware of white slave trade predators, would have further increased the trauma of a decision like Eveline's. By displacing the proposed elopement to Argentina, Joyce's story usefully reflects the more common emigration scenario that did not land poor Irish women and men in Paris, Zurich, or even Trieste, but rather on the uncertain shores of the Americas or Australia. Joyce writing of "Eveline" in the interval when his own young woman was making her decision could therefore be construed as either a proleptic exoneration or a proleptic homage to Nora. The story functions both as a gesture of understanding the feeling of peril that might make a young woman unable to go through with an elopement or, conversely, a reversed tribute to the courage required by one who did. The twenty-two-year-old Joyce, having already failed once as an émigré, had no illusions about the lives Irishmen lived abroad, nor about the adventure upon which he embarked his young woman. Brenda Maddox extends homage to both of them—"As they turned their backs on Ireland, at twenty-two and twenty, Joyce and Nora had enormous courage" (46).

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